TA studio brief — Make the identity piece: pattern and portrait

Pathway: TRACK · Week 4 Part 1 · Big question: How can we combine a bold repeating background pattern with a high-contrast central identity subject?

TA practical setup & focus

Have hairdryers (staff-operated at a safe distance) or blotting paper ready so background washes dry quickly before final contour work.

Studio kit: Week 3 composition plans, heavy cartridge card, graphite pencils, oil pastels/wax crayons, water-based ink/paint washes, black brush pens

Key words to prompt

• figure-ground: The visual separation between the main subject (figure) and the background space (ground).

• rhythm: A visual beat created by repeating shapes, lines, or colours across a pattern.

• halo: A thin band of contrasting tone around the main subject that makes it pop forward.

• opaque: Solid colour that covers the surface underneath completely.

• translucent: Semi-clear colour wash that lets underlying drawing or wax marks show through.

Supported route steps

1. Use your Week 3 plan or a centre guide frame to sketch your main identity symbol large on heavy card.

2. Draw a repeating pattern of lines and dots around the background using bright oil pastels.

3. Brush a contrasting watercolour or ink wash over the background pattern.

4. Fill your central symbol with bold dry tone and trace its outer edge with a thick black marker.

Check: Large central motif with oil-pastel resist patterned background and bold contour.

Review & exit support

Exit question: What does 'figure-ground separation' mean in a composition?

Staff note: Staff preparation only: review a short studio demonstration of oil-pastel pattern resist combined with central tonal rendering.